DCTVU

DC TELEVISION UNIVERSE

Franchise Bible — Volume 01: Foundations

FORMAT • TONE • CONTINUITY • CANON • TEAMS & FOUNDING ROSTERS

An alternate-history story told through Hollywood trades, headlines,
social media, the internet, and screenplay-format scenes.

Story present: 2010.
Six live-action series + two animated series. One multiverse.

Internal development document. Fictional actors and the individual series to be created in later volumes.

Section 0 — Locked-In Ground Rules

STATUS: LOCKED. These rules govern every future installment of the DCTVU story and will not change unless you change them.

#	Rule	Detail
1	Alternate history, real world	Our present is the year **2010**. The story moves forward from there, in a real world where the DCTVU exists.
2	How the story is told	Hollywood trade articles and headlines, social media (2010-era: Twitter, Facebook, MySpace, YouTube, blogs, message boards), and the wider internet, plus **lots of character-driven dialogue in screenplay format**.
3	Timeline discipline	Every entry has a **date and time** (time zone noted). Every person's age is calculated from their **exact birthday** on the date of that entry.
4	Tone of the telling	Creative, interesting, entertaining, dramatic, realistic, and original. It should feel true to how the industry and fandom really behaved in 2010.
5	Output format	**PDF only.** Every deliverable is produced as a PDF.
6	The franchise	The **DC Television Universe (DCTVU)**: a shared multiverse of interconnected series built on DC Comics characters. It fills the role of **both the DCU and the Arrowverse**.
7	Scope	**Six live-action series and two animated series**, linked by shared plot elements, settings, cast, characters, and crossovers.
8	Canon policy	**100% comic-book accurate and faithful to the source material. Nobody is nerfed.** Ever.
9	Reserved for you	**You** create the fictional actors who exist alongside real actors. **You** create the TV series. Neither is invented in this volume.

Section 1 — The Serialized / Standalone Balance

> **RECOMMENDATION: 65% serialized / 35% standalone**, applied *inside* every episode rather than by alternating "mythology" and "filler" episodes.

Why 65/35. A shared universe runs on continuity. Crossovers, team-ups, and season-long villains only pay off if the audience is following ongoing threads, so the serialized side has to lead. But a classic 22-episode network season needs episodes a new viewer can drop into, that hold up in syndication and reruns, and that let each hero have a "case of the week." The 35% standalone share is what makes each hour a satisfying episode of television, not just a chapter.

Inside the episode

Plot layer	Share of runtime	Function
A-plot	about 50%	Usually a self-contained threat, case, or villain that is introduced and resolved within the hour (the standalone core).
B-plot	about 30%	The season arc: the big bad, the mystery, the slow-burn conspiracy. Always moves forward at least one step.
C-plot	about 20%	Character continuity: relationships, secret identities, civilian life, and seeds for crossovers and future seasons.

Across the season (22 episodes)

Episodes	Role in the season
1–3	Premiere block. Establish the status quo, the season villain, and the central question.
4–8	Mostly standalone-forward hours (60/40), each one quietly tightening the arc.
9–10	Fall finale and crossover window. A heavily serialized, high-stakes turn.
11–16	Midseason return. The arc escalates; standalone hours now reveal arc information.
17	Spring crossover window or backdoor-pilot slot.
18–22	Endgame. Nearly fully serialized (85–90%), climax, and a cliffhanger that feeds the shared universe.

Continuity Protocol (non-negotiable)

- **One Master Timeline.** A single in-universe calendar for every series. Every on-screen event gets a date. Every character gets a canonical birthday, and ages are always correct.
- **Story Group.** A central DCTVU Story Group, with showrunners from all eight series, signs off on every arc, death, resurrection, identity reveal, and power level.
- **Consequences carry over.** What happens on one show is real on every show. A city destroyed in one series stays destroyed in another series' background.
- **Crossover calendar.** Fixed annual crossover windows (fall and spring) are planned a year ahead so arcs can line up.
- **Earth designations.** Every series and character is assigned an Earth in the multiverse (Earth-1, Earth-2, and so on). Travel between Earths follows established comic rules.

- **Character bible.** One canonical file per character: powers, weaknesses, history, relationships, costume, and secret-identity status, updated after every episode.
- **No retcons for convenience.** A retcon is allowed only when it comes from the comics, such as a Crisis-scale event, and it has to be earned on screen.

Section 2 — Genre, Subgenres, Rating & Runtime

FRANCHISE GENRE: Superhero Action-Adventure Drama, a serialized ensemble drama in which each series carries its own signature subgenre. The universe stays unified, and each show still feels distinct.

Subgenre palette (each series will be built from these)

Subgenre	What it brings	Classic DC home
Science fiction	Speed Force, alien worlds, time travel, technology	Flash, Superman, Green Lantern, Legion
Crime noir / detective	Street-level mysteries, organized crime, gothic city	Batman family, Question, Birds of Prey
Mythological epic	Gods, legends, destiny	Wonder Woman, Aquaman, Shazam
Space opera	Galactic war, Corps politics, cosmic stakes	Green Lantern Corps, Martian Manhunter
Supernatural horror	Magic, demons, the occult	Justice League Dark, Constantine, Spectre, Fate
Political / spy thriller	Black ops, government conspiracies, morally grey missions	Suicide Squad, Checkmate, A.R.G.U.S.
Coming-of-age	Sidekicks stepping out of their mentors' shadows	Teen Titans, Young Justice
Period drama	The Golden Age, World War II, legacy	Justice Society of America

Rating

TV-14 across the franchise (live-action and animated). In the 2010 broadcast landscape, TV-14 is the ceiling for prime-time network and basic-cable drama. It allows real stakes, real violence, real deaths, intense horror for the magic shows, and adult themes, while staying broad enough for families and syndication. The source material is never softened to fit the rating. Intensity comes from storytelling and consequence, not gore. Selected arcs, especially Suicide Squad and Justice League Dark material, push to the top of TV-14 with **TV-14-LV** and **TV-14-DLSV** descriptors.

Runtime

Format	Episode runtime	Broadcast slot
Live-action series	42–44 minutes (content)	One-hour block with commercials
Animated series	22 minutes (content)	Half-hour block with commercials
Crossover events	Each part 42–44 min; premieres may run 60–90 min	Event nights and two-hour specials
Season premieres / finales	Optional 60-min extended cut	Network discretion

Section 3 — Episode Count: Back to Our Roots

RECOMMENDATION: 22 episodes per season for live-action. 26 episodes per season for animation.

22 episodes (live-action) is the classic American network season: September premiere, fall run, holiday hiatus, midseason return, and a May sweeps finale. It is the length that built shared-universe television, giving room for case-of-the-week stories, character development, two crossover windows, and backdoor pilots, without the padding of a 24-episode order. Across six live-action series, that comes to **132 live-action hours per year**.

26 episodes (animation) follows the classic syndicated animation order of the *Batman: The Animated Series* and *Justice League Unlimited* era. Across two animated series, that is **52 half-hours per year**. Animation is where the franchise can put the full cosmic scale on screen, unrestricted by budget, and its events are canon in the shared timeline.

Month	Live-action (22)	Animated (26)
Sept–Oct	Premieres; Eps 1–7	Eps 1–10
Nov–early Dec	Eps 8–10; FALL CROSSOVER (November sweeps)	Eps 11–15
Jan–Feb	Eps 11–15 (February sweeps)	Eps 16–21
Mar–Apr	Eps 16–18; SPRING CROSSOVER	Eps 22–26
May	Eps 19–22; finales (May sweeps)	Reruns / specials

Section 4 — Canon Policy: 100% Comic Accurate, Nobody Nerfed

- **Power levels match the comics.** Superman moves planets. The Flash taps the Speed Force at full potential, including time travel. Wonder Woman is a demigod warrior on Superman's level. Green Lantern is limited only by will. Martian Manhunter keeps his full suite: shapeshifting, telepathy, phasing, invisibility, flight, and Kryptonian-tier strength.
- **No powers lost for budget.** A power is never written out because it is expensive to show. The production budgets for it, or the moment moves to animation.
- **Weaknesses are honored, not invented.** Kryptonite, magic, and red-sun radiation; fire for J'onn J'onzz; the Lantern Corps' classic yellow impurity and ring charge. Only canonical limits apply.
- **Costumes are comic-faithful.** Classic colors, emblems, capes, masks, and full codenames, with heroes in costume on screen.
- **Origins, identities, and relationships come from the comics.** No gender-, race-, or role-swaps, no merging two characters into one, and no invented family ties.
- **Villains are not nerfed either.** Darkseid, Brainiac, Sinestro, Reverse-Flash, Lex Luthor, and Ra's al Ghul are written at full menace.
- **Smart heroes, smart villains.** No idiot plots, and no hero made weaker so the story can work.

Section 5 — The Premier Team

THE JUSTICE LEAGUE OF AMERICA, with its **original Silver Age founding roster** from *The Brave and the Bold* #28 (cover date March 1960): the seven founders as they appear in the comics.

Why the JLA. It is DC's flagship team and the pillar that both the DCU and the Arrowverse were built toward. The 1960 lineup is the definitive, comic-accurate founding roster, and it gives the DCTVU seven iconic heroes who each carry a corner of the universe: city, street, myth, speed, cosmos, sea, and space. Every series can feed into the League, and the League can tie every series together.

#	Hero	Alter ego	Corner of the universe	Core powers (unnerfed)
1	Superman	Kal-El / Clark Kent	Metropolis, Krypton	Near-invulnerability, flight, super strength and speed, heat vision, X-ray and telescopic vision, freeze breath, super hearing, solar-powered
2	Batman	Bruce Wayne	Gotham City	Peak human, world's greatest detective, master strategist and martial artist, unlimited resources, contingency planning
3	Wonder Woman	Princess Diana of Themyscira	Themyscira, the Greek gods	Demigod strength and durability, flight, Lasso of Truth, bracelets, master warrior
4	The Flash	Barry Allen	Central City, the Speed Force	Fastest man alive, Speed Force connection, time travel, molecular phasing, accelerated perception and healing
5	Green Lantern	Hal Jordan	Coast City, Green Lantern Corps, Sector 2814	Power ring constructs limited only by willpower, flight, space travel, force fields
6	Aquaman	Arthur Curry / Orin	Atlantis, the Seven Seas	Atlantean strength and durability, marine telepathy, underwater mobility, king of the oceans
7	Martian Manhunter	J'onn J'onzz / John Jones	Mars, Middleton, Colorado	Telepathy, shapeshifting, phasing, invisibility, flight, super strength, Martian vision

Planned expansion members (later seasons, all comic-accurate): Green Arrow (Oliver Queen), the Atom (Ray Palmer), Hawkman (Katar Hol), Black Canary (Dinah Lance), Zatanna, Elongated Man (Ralph Dibny), Red Tornado, Firestorm (Ronnie Raymond), and Hawkgirl.

Base of operations: the Secret Sanctuary inside a mountain near Happy Harbor, Rhode Island. The Justice League Satellite comes later.

Section 6 — Supporting Teams & Original Rosters

Each supporting team uses its **original, comic-accurate founding lineup**. Together they cover every era and tone of the DC Universe, from the 1940s legacy heroes to the far future, and from black ops to the occult.

1. JUSTICE SOCIETY OF AMERICA — The Legacy Team

Debut: *All-Star Comics* #3 (Winter 1940). The first superhero team, made up of the Golden Age heroes of World War II, and the source of the franchise's legacy and multiverse mythology.

Hero	Alter ego
The Flash	Jay Garrick
Green Lantern	Alan Scott
Hawkman	Carter Hall
Doctor Fate	Kent Nelson
The Spectre	Jim Corrigan
Hourman	Rex Tyler
Sandman	Wesley Dodds
The Atom	Al Pratt

2. TEEN TITANS — The Next Generation

Debut: *The Brave and the Bold* #54 (July 1964) with Robin, Kid Flash, and Aqualad. Wonder Girl joined in *B&B* #60, and the full team launched in *Showcase* #59 (1965) with Speedy.

Hero	Alter ego
Robin	Dick Grayson
Kid Flash	Wally West
Aqualad	Garth
Wonder Girl	Donna Troy
Speedy	Roy Harper

3. SUICIDE SQUAD (Task Force X) — The Black-Ops Team

Modern founding: *Legends* #3 (1987) and *Suicide Squad* #1 (1987), by John Ostrander. Government-run supervillains sent on deniable missions.

Member	Identity / role
Amanda Waller	Director (“The Wall”)
Rick Flag	Field leader
Bronze Tiger	Ben Turner
Deadshot	Floyd Lawton
Captain Boomerang	George “Digger” Harkness
Enchantress	June Moone
Blockbuster	Mark Desmond
Plastique	Bette Sans Souci
Nightshade	Eve Eden

4. BIRDS OF PREY — The Street-Level Team

Debut: *Black Canary/Oracle: Birds of Prey* #1 (1996), with Huntress joining as the third core member.

Hero	Alter ego
Oracle	Barbara Gordon
Black Canary	Dinah Lance
Huntress	Helena Bertinelli

5. JUSTICE LEAGUE DARK — The Supernatural Team

Original lineup from *Justice League Dark* #1. Magic-users who handle threats too strange for the League.

Hero	Alter ego
Hellblazer	John Constantine
Zatanna	Zatanna Zatara
Madame Xanadu	Nimue Inwudu
Deadman	Boston Brand
Shade, the Changing Man	Rac Shade

6. THE OUTSIDERS — Batman's Strike Team

Debut: *The Brave and the Bold* #200 and *Batman and the Outsiders* #1 (1983). Formed when Batman quit the League to act where the League would not.

Hero	Alter ego
Batman	Bruce Wayne (leader)
Black Lightning	Jefferson Pierce
Geo-Force	Prince Brion Markov
Katana	Tatsu Yamashiro
Metamorpho	Rex Mason
Halo	Gabrielle Doe

7. DOOM PATROL — The World's Strangest Heroes

Debut: *My Greatest Adventure* #80 (1963).

Hero	Alter ego
The Chief	Dr. Niles Caulder
Robotman	Cliff Steele
Negative Man	Larry Trainor
Elasti-Girl	Rita Farr

8. LEGION OF SUPER-HEROES — The Future Team (31st Century)

Debut: *Adventure Comics* #247 (1958). Teen heroes from the future inspired by the legend of Superman.

Hero	Alter ego
Cosmic Boy	Rokk Krinn
Saturn Girl	Imra Ardeen
Lightning Lad	Garth Ranzz

9. GREEN LANTERN CORPS — The Cosmic Police Force

The intergalactic peacekeepers of Oa. Core featured lineup for the DCTVU:

Lantern	Sector / role
Hal Jordan	Sector 2814 (shared with the JLA)
Abin Sur	Sector 2814 (predecessor)
Sinestro	Sector 1417 (mentor, then villain)
Kilowog	Drill sergeant, Sector 674
Tomar-Re	Sector 2813
Guy Gardner	Backup Lantern, Earth
John Stewart	Backup Lantern, Earth

Antagonist teams (to be deployed later)

- **Secret Society of Super-Villains** and **Injustice Gang**: the League's organized opposition.
- **The Rogues** (Captain Cold, Heat Wave, Mirror Master, Weather Wizard, Captain Boomerang, the Trickster): Central City's criminal family.
- **Injustice Society**: the JSA's Golden Age enemies.
- **The Fearsome Five** and **Brotherhood of Evil**: the Titans' and Doom Patrol's nemeses.
- **Sinestro Corps**: the yellow-ring army, foreshadowed from Season 1.

Section 7 — Summary & Next Steps

Decision	Locked answer
Serialized / standalone	65% serialized / 35% standalone, blended inside every episode
Continuity	Master Timeline, Story Group, Earth designations, character bible, no convenience retcons
Genre	Superhero action-adventure drama, with a signature subgenre per series
Rating	TV-14 franchise-wide, with descriptors (LV, DLSV) for intense arcs
Runtime	42–44 min (live-action) / 22 min (animated)
Episodes per season	22 (live-action) / 26 (animated)
Canon	100% comic-accurate. Nobody nerfed, heroes or villains.
Premier team	Justice League of America: Superman, Batman, Wonder Woman, Flash (Barry Allen), Green Lantern (Hal Jordan), Aquaman, Martian Manhunter
Supporting teams	JSA, Teen Titans, Suicide Squad, Birds of Prey, Justice League Dark, Outsiders, Doom Patrol, Legion of Super-Heroes, Green Lantern Corps

Awaiting your input

- **Fictional actors:** you create them, and they will exist alongside real 2010 Hollywood actors. Their birthdays will anchor all age calculations.
- **The six live-action and two animated series:** you create them. They will slot into the format, tone, rating, and continuity rules above.
- Then the story begins in **2010**, told through trade announcements, headlines, early-2010s social media and fan reaction, and screenplay-format scenes, all with dated, time-stamped entries.